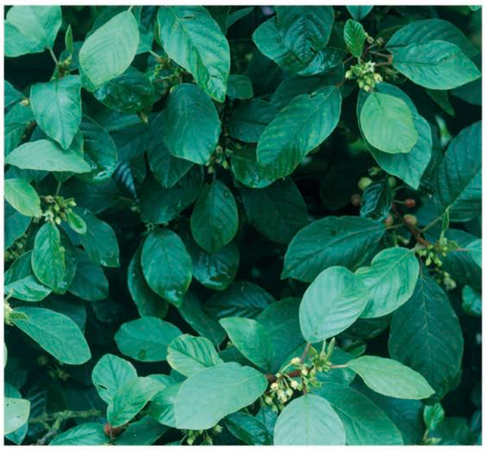
Once dried and stored, it is significantly milder than senna (*Cassia senna*, p. 75) or common buckthorn (*R. catharticus*) and may be safely used over the long term to treat constipation and to encourage the return of regular bowel movements. Alder buckthorn is a particularly beneficial remedy if the muscles of the colon are weak, and if there is poor bile flow. The plant should not be used for constipation caused by excessive tension in the colon wall.



***Alder buckthorn** bark is toxic when fresh but is safe to use once dried and stored for a year.*

Related Species Cascara sagrada (*R. purshiana*), native to woodlands along the Pacific coast of North America, is used medicinally in much the same way as alder buckthorn. Common buckthorn (*R. cartharticus*), a European native, is today used mainly in veterinary medicine.
Cautions Use only dried bark that has been stored for at least a year, as the fresh bark is violently purgative. The berries may also be harmful if eaten.

Rhus glabra (Anacardiaceae)
Smooth Sumac

Description Deciduous shrub growing to a height of about 6½ ft (2 m). Has straggling branches, compound leaves in pairs, large clusters of greenish-red flowers, and downy deep red berries.
Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, smooth sumac is found on the borders of woods, along fences and roadsides, and in neglected sites. The root bark is collected in autumn, the berries when ripe in late summer.
Parts Used Root bark, berries.
Constituents Smooth sumac contains tannins. Its other constituents are unknown.
History & Folklore Indigenous peoples across North America used smooth sumac and closely related species to treat hemorroids, rectal bleeding, dysentery, venereal disease, and bleeding after childbirth. John Josselyn, a 17th-century New England naturalist, observed: "the English use to boyl [the plant] in beer, and drink it for colds; and so do the Indians, from whom the English had the medicine."
Medicinal Actions & Uses The astringent root bark of smooth sumac is often used as a decoction. It is taken to alleviate diarrhea and dysentery, applied externally to treat excessive vaginal discharge and skin eruptions, and used as a gargle for sore throats. The berries are diuretic, help reduce fever, and may be of use in type 2 diabetes. The berries are also astringent and can be used as a gargle for both mouth and throat complaints.
Related Species Sweet sumac (*R. aromatica*) has a similar range of uses. Poison ivy (*R. toxicodendron*) was formerly used in herbal medicine as a treatment for rheumatism, paralysis, and certain skin disorders. It is itself highly irritant to the skin, and causes severe dermatitis.

Ribes nigrum (Grossulariaceae)
Blackcurrant

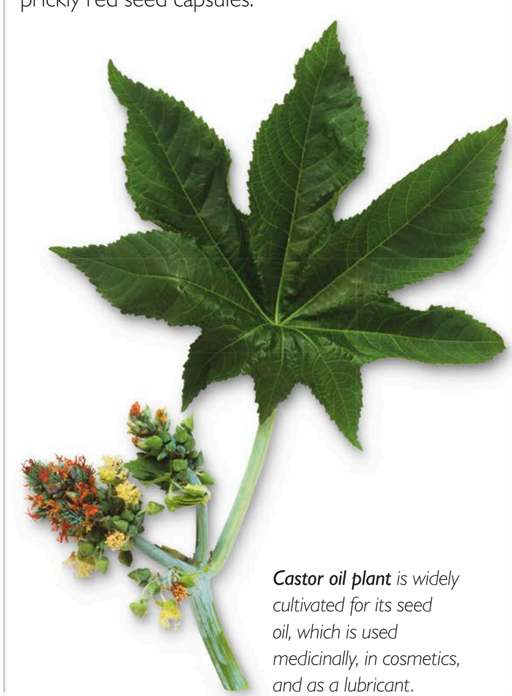
Description Erect deciduous shrub growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has serrated, palm-shaped lobed leaves, small greenish-white flowers, and clusters of black berries.

***Blackcurrant** fruit is harvested in summer. The juice is extremely rich in vitamin C.*

Habitat & Cultivation Blackcurrant is native to the temperate regions of Europe, western and central Asia, and the Himalayas. It is grown mainly in eastern Europe for its sour-sweet fruit. The leaves are gathered in early summer, the berries when ripe in mid to late summer.
Parts Used Leaves, berries.
Constituents Blackcurrant leaves contain flavonoids, tannins, proanthocyanidins, prodelphinidins, and a volatile oil. The berries contain flavonoids, flavonols, proanthocyanidins and sugars (10–15%). The seeds contain the essential fatty acids linoleic and alpha-linolenic acids, and up to 18% gamma-linolenic acid and 9% stearidonic acid. (However, most blackcurrant oil available on the market has been refined and will not contain these oils.) The proanthocyanidins, especially in the fruit, are strongly antioxidant and anti-inflammatory, and like bilberry (*Vaccinium myrtilis*, p. 147) exert a protective activity on the capillaries. The prodelphinidins are anti-inflammatory.
Medicinal Actions & Uses In Europe, blackcurrant leaves are used for their diuretic effect. By encouraging the elimination of fluid, the leaves help to reduce blood volume and thereby to lower blood pressure. The leaves are also used as a gargle for sore throats and mouth ulcers. According to French investigators, blackcurrant leaves increase the secretion of cortisol by the adrenal glands, and thus stimulate the activity of the sympathetic nervous system. This action may prove useful in the treatment of stress-related conditions. Blackcurrant berries and their juice are high in vitamin C. They help improve resistance to infection and make a valuable remedy for treating colds and flu. According to the herbal authority R. F. Weiss, the juice is "as good as, if not better than, lemon juice (*Citrus limon*) for patients with pneumonia, influenza, etc." The juice also helps to stem diarrhea and calms indigestion. Juice that is fresh or vacuum-sealed is more effective than concentrate.

Ricinus communis (Euphorbiaceae)
Castor Oil Plant

Description Evergreen shrub growing to about 33 ft (10 m) in its natural state, but a much smaller annual when cultivated. Has large, palm-shaped leaves, green female flowers, and prickly red seed capsules.



***Castor oil plant** is widely cultivated for its seed oil, which is used medicinally, in cosmetics, and as a lubricant.*